

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



People walk through the snow along North Michigan Avenue as a storm passes through Saturday in Chicago. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

HARD CHILL TO SWALLOW

Snowy, cold start to winter follows a fall that was giving Chicagoans August vibes, but climate change might be driving unpredictability

By **Adriana Pérez** | Chicago Tribune

After years of little snow across the Chicago area, recent record-breaking snowfall and below-freezing temperatures might seem to contradict scientific reports of winters getting warmer. But climate change is still transforming how locals experience the changing seasons, including this fall, one of the top 10 warmest recorded in Illinois. “People are like, ‘Oh, look at this snow. It’s not climate change,’” said Trent Ford, the Illinois state climatologist.

But trends in recent decades point to an overall warming of average temperatures in winter as well as fall, spring and summer, from human activities such as fossil-fuel burning that release heat-trapping gases into the atmosphere. And that overall warming doesn’t rule out some occasional outliers, including the extreme cold this week.

“Winter is, in fact, starting later as well,” Ford said, even if cold and snow this year might seemingly point to the contrary.

When thinking about climate change’s impact on seasons, he said, “We talk about the winter a lot — winter warming — and certainly we talk about more summer heat, things like that. Fall is sort of forgotten about. What’s really interesting is that all seasons, all months, are warming.”

In Chicago, fall is the second fastest-warming season after winter, according to climate science nonprofit Climate Central. Preliminary reports from weather stations across Illinois show statewide average temperatures this fall were 2.5 to 3 degrees above normal, Ford said.

This might only translate to the difference between buying an ice-cold apple cider — instead of a more seasonally appropriate hot version — on

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Va. man arrested in DC pipe bomb case

Agents struggled for years to track down suspect despite tips

By **Eric Tucker and Alanna Durkin Richer**
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — The FBI on Thursday arrested a man accused of placing two pipe bombs outside the headquarters of the Republican and Democratic national parties in Washington on the eve of the U.S. Capitol attack, an abrupt breakthrough in an investigation that for years flummoxed law enforcement and spawned conspiracy theories about Jan. 6, 2021.

The arrest marks the first time investigators have publicly identified a suspect in an act that has been an enduring mystery for nearly five years in the shadow of the violent Capitol insurrection.

The suspect was identified as Brian Cole Jr., 30, of Woodbridge, Virginia, but key questions remain unanswered after his arrest on explosives charges, including a possible motive and what connection if any the act had to the assault on the Capitol the following day by supporters of President Donald Trump.

Law enforcement officials used credit purchases of bomb-making materials, cell-phone tower data and a license plate reader to zero in on Cole, according to an FBI affidavit filed in the case. The FBI and Justice Department officials declined to elaborate on what led them to the suspect, but characterized his arrest as the result of a reinvigorated investigation and a fresh analysis of already collected evidence and data.

“Let me be clear: There was no new tip. There was no new witness. Just good diligent police work and prosecutorial work,” Attorney General Pam

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‘WE JUST REALLY SAW A PARALLEL’

Evanston church’s Nativity scene depicted baby Jesus zip-tied by immigration agents

By **Richard Requena**
Pioneer Press

Mother Mary wearing a respirator to protect herself from tear gas. Baby Jesus with zip-tied hands, wrapped in a thin blanket that looks like aluminum foil. Masked centurions with sunglasses and green vests labeled “ICE.”

This is how the Lake Street Church of Evanston chose to assemble its outdoor Nativity scene for the Christmas season. The church and its leaders have been vocal critics of the Trump administration’s Operation

Midway Blitz, which roiled the Chicago region from September through November, and expressed a message with their holiday decorations.

“Enforcement terror does not discriminate by documentation status,” the church wrote on its Facebook page on Nov. 25.

The organizer of the Nativity scene, Associate Minister Jillian Westerfield, told Pioneer Press that in the months prior to organizing it, she has been reflecting on the impact of Operation Midway Blitz, in which hundreds

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The Rev. Michael Woolf, above, outside Lake Street Church of Evanston on Thursday. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

CHA says it was pushed to install mayor’s ally

By **Alice Yin**
Chicago Tribune

The Chicago Housing Authority board told the federal government this fall that Mayor Brandon Johnson was pressuring the agency behind the scenes to install a close political ally to lead the nation’s third-largest public housing agency.

CHA board Chair Matthew Brewer wrote to the U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development on Oct. 1 laying out what he said were Johnson’s attempts to influence the agency to name former Ald. Walter Burnett Jr. as CEO, according to a copy of the letter obtained by the Tribune. The six-page message said the public housing agency’s board of commissioners never seriously considered Burnett,



Mayor Brandon Johnson, right, shakes hands with Matthew Brewer, interim board chairman of the Chicago Housing Authority, on Feb. 27. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

noting he lacked management experience, and only interviewed him as a courtesy.

Brewer was first appointed to the board by Mayor Rahm Emanuel before Johnson named him its interim chair last year. The board appointed him interim CEO, too, when Angela Hurlock resigned that post in September. He then wrote to HUD’s public housing director just before the federal government shutdown in response to HUD’s request for

additional information on the CHA CEO selection process.

In his letter, Brewer wrote that the effort to find a permanent leader had been delayed for several months because Johnson was pushing the board to appoint Burnett to the post.

“We informed the Mayor that we do not recommend him as CEO,” Brewer wrote. “The Mayor has continued with his

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BUDGET BATTLE: Mayor Brandon Johnson’s administration on Thursday publicly shot down the 2026 budget plan backed by a narrow City Council majority, doubling down on his head tax proposal. **Chicagoland, Page 4**

CPS settles sex abuse case

The Chicago Board of Education approved a \$17.5 million settlement Wednesday over the sexual abuse of a student by a former Little Village high school dean. The deal is believed to be the largest of its kind in state history. **Chicagoland, Page 2**

Bears corner back ‘a fighter’

Bears cornerback Jaylon Johnson needed more than physical rehabilitation to return to the field last week against the Eagles — a journey that would challenge most players’ mental fortitude. **Chicago Sports**

